NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 2♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥Q

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 6♥
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠8

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: South
Lead: ♦K

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♠10

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

♠ Q 3
♥ A 8 6
♦ Q 7 5 2
♣ A K 9 4

♠ A 6
♥ K 9 2
♦ K J 3
♣ J 8 7 3 2



♠ J 10 2
♥ Q J 10 3
♦ A 10 4
♣ 10 6 5

♠ K 9 8 7 5 4
♥ 7 5 4
♦ 9 8 6
♣ Q

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♥
Pass	2♠		
All Pass			

2♠ by North
Lead: ♥Q

Surely this hand will play better in ♠s than in notrump. So you transfer with 2♥ and partner bids 2♠.

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You pass. In the old days, before transfers, you would have bid 2♠ with this hand as a sign-off. The only difference is that now partner gets to play it.

The contract would be 2♠ played by South.

North plays 2♠. East leads the ♥Q and West plays the ♥9.

Loser List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 3 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 7

Suppose you win the ♥A, play over to the ♣Q, then try to get back to your hand with a trump to discard 2 losers on ♣ A K. If it worked that way it would be fine, but it is very likely that a defender would win their trump Ace, then take their 2 ♥s and 3 ♦s. You could be down one before you even got started.

A better approach is to trade one of your ♣ winners for a quick discard. Take the ♥A, then play ♣ A K, discarding a ♥ from dummy. That will eliminate one ♥ loser.

You probably cannot avoid your 3 ♦ losers, but you may be able to get out with losing a single trump. **IF** ♠s split 3-2, and **IF** you can win tricks with both the ♠K and ♠Q then you will make it. The only way it can happen is if West holds a doubleton ♠ A x. You must play the first ♠ from dummy, so ruff a ♣ to get there, then lead a small ♠, putting on your ♠Q when West follows low. This wins the trick, (hip-hip), so you now play your ♠3, ducking in dummy. When West has to take his ♠A, (hooray), you are home-free.

With West holding the ♠A, this Plan clearly works.

But, if you need West to hold the ♠ A x anyway, perhaps that first plan would have worked better. You know, take dummy's ♣Q, then play a low ♠ to get to your hand.

It depends on West. If he ducked the low ♠ then you could get **TWO** discards and make an overtrick.

The method given here gives up the possibility of an overtrick for an improved chance of making the contract. You choose.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ K J 6 2 ♥ 3 ♦ 9 8 4 2 ♣ Q 10 6 3	
♠ A 7 5 3 ♥ K J 10 9 4 ♦ Q 6 5 ♣ 7	N W E S	♠ Q 10 9 4 ♥ A Q 8 6 ♦ A K ♣ A J 4
	♠ 8 ♥ 7 5 2 ♦ J 10 7 3 ♣ K 9 8 5 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		2NT	Pass
3♣	Pass	3♥	Pass
6♥			
All Pass			

6♥ by East
Lead: ♠8

First find out about Major suit fits by bidding Stayman. So bid 3♣ and partner says 3♥. What now?

First find out about Major suit fits by bidding Stayman. So bid 3♣ and partner says 3♥. What now?

Feel free to use Blackwood. But if partner shows 3 Aces you only have enough points to bid 6, and if he shows 2 Aces you would still bid 6. So Blackwood will keep you out of slam if he has only 1 Ace. Or, you could just take a chance and bid 6♥.

The contract would be 6♥ played by West.

To rotate the hands and make East the declarer

East plays 6♥. South leads the ♠8. To play the ♠A or not to play the ♠A, that is the question.

Loser List: ♠ = 2? : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 2

At first thought it seems the ♠ lead has saved you a guess in the suit. By playing low in dummy you will force North to put on the King, (if he has it), winning the trick but leaving you with a pretty good position in ♠s.

That's why it's good to have second thoughts at the Bridge table. Think about the meaning of the ♠8 lead. If it is fourth down, then the Rule of 11 tells you that there will be 3 cards higher than the 8 spread among West, North, and East. **BUT YOU CAN SEE 4 HIGHER CARDS**. So your conclusion is that South has **NOT** made a fourth-down lead, but rather has led top-of-nothing, top-of-a-doubleton, or perhaps a singleton.

You don't know which of the above, but you do know that North holds both the ♠ K J. The danger is if the ♠8 is a singleton and you play low from dummy they could get a ♠ trick and a ♠ ruff. So don't play low from dummy. Win the ♠A at trick 1, pull trumps and then play ♠s from dummy toward your ♠ Q 10 9, giving North the ♠K but finessing him out of his known ♠J.

If North led the ♠8 from ♠ 8 6 2 then it wouldn't matter whether you played the ♠A or not, you would always make the contract.

If North led the ♠8 from ♠ 8 6 or ♠ 8 2 then it also wouldn't matter whether you played the ♠A or not, you would always make the contract.

If North led the singleton ♠8 then you had better play the ♠A or you will be down before you start.

It is unlikely that North would lead the ♠8 from any holding containing one or both of the honors.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

♠ 7 5
♥ K 8 5 3
♦ 10
♣ A Q 9 8 4 2

♠ 9 8 6
♥ Q J 9 2
♦ K Q J 7
♣ 10 5



♠ Q J 10 4 2
♥ 10
♦ A 9 5 4 3
♣ 7 6

♠ A K 3
♥ A 7 6 4
♦ 8 6 2
♣ K J 3

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2♣	Pass	2♥
Pass	4♥		
All Pass			

4♥ by South
Lead: ♦K

Never mind trying to decide how to show the ♣ suit; with a 4-card Major your obligation is to use Stayman.

You say 2♣ and partner bids 2♥. What now?

Never mind trying to decide how to show the ♣ suit; with a 4-card Major your obligation is to use Stayman.

You say 2♣ and partner bids 2♥. What now?

Again, never mind the ♣ suit. You have an 8-card Major fit and enough points for game, so you bid 4♥.

The contract would be 4♥ played by North.

South plays 4♥. West leads the ♦K. The ♦K holds the trick and West switches to the ♠9.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 1/2 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 2/3

This looks like a walk in the park. Play 2 rounds of trumps, and if they split 3-2 go ahead and force the master trump out. The rest of the tricks would then be yours.

But East shows out on the second trump lead. Ouch!

DO NOT PLAY ANOTHER TRUMP!If you do, then West will pull all the trumps and then East/West will win some ♦s. Many, many ♦s.

Instead just start playing good ♣s. West can ruff in whenever he wants but you will maintain trump control. West can get both master trumps but nothing else.

It is usually correct to leave a master trump undrawn, just let the defender ruff in whenever he wants.

Here that principle applied even though there were **TWO** master trumps out.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ 10 9 7 4 ♥ J 9 6 ♦ 10 8 5 ♣ A Q J	
♠ A J 6 ♥ K 8 4 ♦ A K 6 ♣ 7 5 4 2	N W E S	♠ K Q 3 ♥ A 7 3 ♦ Q J 3 ♣ 10 9 6 3
	♠ 8 5 2 ♥ Q 10 5 2 ♦ 9 7 4 2 ♣ K 8	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	Pass	3NT	
All Pass			

3NT by West
Lead: ♠10

With 12 points and no 4-card Major suit this one is easy. You bid 3NT of course.

The contract would be 3NT played by East.

West plays 3NT. North leads the ♠10 and South follows with the ♠2.

Winner List: ♠ = 3 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 3 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 8

There is just no way your ninth winner can come from ♠s, ♥s, or ♦s. So by process of elimination you have to get a ♣ trick.

Win the first trick, probably in your hand, and play a ♣.

A defender will definitely win this, and probably continue ♠s (but if they switch you would play the same way). You win the ♠ and play another ♣.

North wins and plays another ♠; you win and play another ♣. Deja vu.

North wins again, cashed his established ♠, and exits with a red card. You win and claim the rest of the tricks, including your now-established ♣.

You were able to establish a ♣ because that suit split 3-2.

And you did it without going down because the ♠s split 4-3.

This may seem lucky to you, but don't knock it, it was your **ONLY** chance.